

PRODUCT VISION & ROADMAP

HalalForMe

Building the daily Muslim companion app — prayer-first, privacy-first, and built to earn a place on the home screen, not just the App Store search results.

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1. Why We're Building This

HalalForMe started as a halal restaurant directory. That's a real need, but it's an *occasional-use* product — someone opens a restaurant-finder app a few times a month, if that. An app built only around restaurant discovery will always struggle to become a daily habit, and daily habits are what make an app indispensable rather than disposable.

We asked a founder-level question: if this app didn't exist yet, what would we build for Muslims worldwide from first principles? The answer that kept surfacing was **prayer**. It happens five times a day, for essentially every practicing Muslim, everywhere in the world, with zero "cold start" problem — there's no education needed to explain why someone would want prayer times and a qibla direction. That's the foundation of a real daily habit loop, something a restaurant directory can never be on its own.

The pivot, in one sentence: Prayer times and Qibla become the reason someone opens the app every day. The halal scanner is the strong secondary reason. Restaurant discovery and community features remain valuable, but as supporting modules — not the flagship.

2. The Four Pillars



Prayer Times & Notifications

The daily habit engine. Accurate, location-aware prayer times with a calculation method and madhab that match the user's own tradition, plus timely reminders that respect precaution buffers around fiqh edge cases (e.g. Maghrib).



Qibla Compass

A clean, trustworthy compass that tells you which way to face, reachable directly from the home screen the moment prayer time arrives.



Halal Scanner

Point your camera at a barcode and know in seconds whether a product is halal, haram, or unclear — with a transparent, ingredient-by-ingredient explanation, not just a verdict.



Restaurant Directory

Find halal restaurants nearby, filtered by certification and cuisine. Still a core feature — just no longer the front door to the app.

A fifth pillar, **Community** (contribution points, badges, leaderboard), already exists in the codebase and is intentionally kept off the tab bar until there's a real plan to seed activity — an empty leaderboard is worse than no leaderboard.

3. What's Already Built

This is a snapshot from reading the actual app code, not a plan — everything below exists and works today.

Prayer & Qibla

- Prayer time calculation via the `adhan` library — 12 calculation methods (including Moonsighting Committee Worldwide for moon-sighting-based communities), Hanafi/Shafi madhab toggle, GPS or manual city location
- Configurable precaution buffer (e.g. Maghrib) so notifications never fire before a prayer has genuinely started
- Local notification scheduling, 7 days ahead on a rolling basis, with platform-correct (DST-safe) trigger construction on both iOS and Android
- Background refresh task registered so the notification schedule stays current without the app being opened
- Qibla compass with live heading, alignment feedback ("You're facing Qibla" / "Turn left 12°"), and bearing/heading/accuracy readout

Halal Scanner

- Barcode lookup against Open Food Facts, cross-referenced with a static E-number halal-status table and a set of ingredient-name rules (pork, gelatin, alcohol, carmine, rennet, and more) — the ingredient logic works fully offline
- Full ingredient-by-ingredient breakdown with the specific reason anything is flagged, not just a pass/fail verdict
- Signals for halal certification, vegan/vegetarian labelling, and community-verified products layered on top of the automated analysis
- Scan history, manual barcode entry, and a "report a problem" flow for correcting bad data

Restaurant Directory & Community

- Search, city/zip distance filtering, cuisine and certification filters, open-now and rating filters

- Restaurant detail pages, reviews, photo uploads, a submit-restaurant flow, and a claim-restaurant (ownership) flow
- Community leaderboard (monthly and all-time points, badges, anonymous-name toggle) — built, present in the code, currently hidden from the tab bar

Accounts, Trust & Safety

- Guest browsing — the app is fully usable without an account (a deliberate App Store compliance fix), with account creation only required for account-gated actions like reviews or submissions
- Email/password auth, OTP verification, password reset
- Admin moderation panel: ownership claims, user reports, review moderation, submission approvals
- Account deletion with double confirmation

Design & Visual Identity

- A cream/deep-green/gold visual language rolled out across Home, Qibla, onboarding, Search, Scanner, and Profile, replacing the earlier generic light-grey app look
- A single shared design-token source (`lib/theme.ts`) so every screen pulls from one palette instead of redefining colors locally

4. In Progress Right Now

Item	Status
iOS notification delivery investigation	INVESTIGATING Prayer notifications are being scheduled successfully, but aren't reliably arriving when the app is backgrounded or closed on iOS. This matches a known class of issue in the underlying notification library, not obviously a bug in our own scheduling code. A diagnostic test-notification tool has been added to isolate the exact failure condition before we decide on a fix.
Wider visual consistency pass	IN PROGRESS Home, Qibla, onboarding, Search, Scanner, and Profile now share one design language. Restaurant detail, the submit-restaurant flow, saved/reviews/submissions screens, legal pages, auth screens, and the admin panel still carry the older visual style.

5. What's Planned Next

Near-term

- **Qibla enhancements:** a rotating true-north compass rose (currently a fixed dial with a rotating needle) and a live distance-to-Kaaba readout — deliberately deferred until the current visual redesign was locked in, since these are correctness-sensitive features that need their own on-device verification
- **Finish the visual consistency pass** across the remaining lower-traffic screens (restaurant detail, submit flow, legal pages, auth screens)
- **Background refresh verification:** the background task that keeps notifications current has never been exercised end-to-end on a device — needs a real test pass

Larger gaps to close

Gap	Why it matters
No map view	Restaurant discovery is entirely list-based today (react-native-maps isn't installed). A "restaurants near me" map is a standard expectation for a discovery app and the most visible feature gap versus competitors.
No monetization path	No ads SDK, no subscription/IAP library exists yet. This matters directly because of our own "no ads, no data selling" privacy positioning — we need a revenue model that doesn't compromise that promise (e.g. an optional premium tier) before this becomes a sustainability problem.
No server-side push notifications	Today, expo-notifications is used only for on-device scheduling. There's no backend push channel — meaning we can't yet notify users about things happening outside their own device (e.g. a review reply, a submission approval) without them opening the app.
No automated test suite	Only manual Node scripts validate the prayer/qibla/notification math. As the app grows, this becomes a real regression risk.
Community re-launch	Leaderboard and badges are built but hidden — intentionally, until there's a concrete plan to seed real activity so it doesn't launch to an empty room.

6. What We Won't Do

- **No selling or sharing of location data.** Location is used to compute prayer times, qibla direction, and nearby restaurants — never sold, never shared with third parties.
- **No ad SDKs.** Whatever monetization model we eventually pick, it will not come at the cost of tracking-based advertising.
- **No account requirement to use the core app.** Guest browsing stays fully functional; accounts are only required where they genuinely need to be (reviews, submissions, saved items).

7. Status at a Glance

Feature Area	Status
Prayer times & notifications (core logic)	BUILT
Qibla compass (core)	BUILT
iOS background notification delivery	INVESTIGATING
Qibla rotating compass rose / distance-to-Kaaba	PLANNED
Halal barcode/ingredient scanner	BUILT
Restaurant discovery (list-based)	BUILT
Restaurant discovery (map-based)	NOT STARTED
Community leaderboard & badges	BUILT — hidden pending activity plan
Guest browsing & accounts	BUILT
Admin moderation panel	BUILT
Visual design system (Home/Qibla/Search/Scanner/Profile)	BUILT
Visual design system (remaining screens)	IN PROGRESS
Monetization (subscription/ads-free tier)	NOT STARTED

Server-side push notifications	NOT STARTED
Automated test suite	NOT STARTED